



WEEK EIGHT · MODULE ONE

Your First Ninety Days

Entering a house, and being kept

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

Everything in the last seven weeks was to get you through the door. This week is about not being asked to leave through it.

This is the week that decides whether the programme was worth anything, because a role you lose in six months is not a career.

Read it before your first day. Read it again on your thirtieth. It is a different document by then.

CHAPTER I

Getting in is not the achievement

And why the offer is the easiest part

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the actual failure rate of the first year.

Reset what you think success looks like.

1.1 · The uncomfortable statistic that nobody publishes

A great many people get into this profession. A far smaller number are still in the same house two years later, and a smaller number again are still in the profession at all in five years.

And here is what is remarkable: **almost none of them were dismissed for incompetence.** They were dismissed, or they quietly left, for reasons that are entirely learnable, entirely predictable, and entirely covered in this module.

1.2 · What you are actually doing in the first ninety days

THE REFRAME

You have not been hired. You have been given a trial that lasts ninety days and that nobody will describe to you as a trial.

You will not be told how you are doing. There will be no review, no feedback, and no warning. There will be an accumulation of small observations, and then, one day, a settled view of you that will not be revisited.

1.3 · The objective

Not to impress. Not to demonstrate what you learned. Not to improve anything. **The objective of the first ninety days is to become the person nobody has to think about.**

That is an unglamorous ambition and it is the correct one, and the people who understand it in month one are the people who are still there in year five.

CHAPTER II

The week before you begin

The preparation nobody does

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Arrive already useful.

Understand what you may prepare, and what you must not.

2.1 · What you prepare

- **Your toolkit, blank and ready.** From Week 5. The brief sheet, the observation log, the vendor card, the expense log, the escalation card. You are operational on day one because you brought the systems with you.
- **Your code of conduct, reread.** From Week 3. Read it the night before. You will need it inside three weeks, and you will need it on a day when you were not expecting to.
- **The geography.** The city, the neighbourhood, the routes, the hospital, the pharmacy, the good florist, the nearest airport and how long it actually takes at eight in the morning rather than what the map says.
- **The practical.** Your own documents in order, your own accommodation settled, your own life sorted, because a person managing their own chaos cannot absorb anybody else's.

2.2 · What you never do

You do not research the family. Not their business, not their history, not their photographs, not their children. You will be tempted, and it will feel like diligence, and it is the exact appetite this profession cannot accommodate.

Everything you need to know, you will be told, or you will observe. Everything else is curiosity, and curiosity, in a house, has a different name.

CHAPTER III

Day one

Which is a day of listening, and of almost nothing else

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Get day one exactly right.

Understand what everyone in the house is doing on day one, which is watching you.

Do	Why
Arrive early, and be perfectly ordinary about it.	Not dramatically early. Six minutes. It is noticed once, and then assumed, and being assumed reliable is the foundation of everything.
Learn every name, on the first day, and use them.	Every single person. The gardener. The night driver. The woman who comes on Thursdays. Write them down. Use them tomorrow. This one act does more for your first month than anything else you can do.
Ask, and write it down in front of them.	Ask about everything, cheerfully, once. Writing it down in front of the person is the visible proof that you took them seriously, and it is remembered.
Say very little about yourself.	Nobody has asked. You are not interesting yet, and you should be pleased about that.
Do the unglamorous thing that nobody asked you to do.	And do not mention it. Week 4, in a real house, on the first afternoon.

And three things not to do, and each one has ended a first day:

- **Do not improve anything.** Not the smallest thing. Not the obviously broken thing. Not the thing that would take you eleven minutes. You do not yet know why it is like that, and there is always a why, and it is usually a person.
- **Do not mention how it was done in your last house.** Ever, but especially not in the first month, and especially not to the staff. It is the most reliable way to be disliked in a fortnight.

- **Do not be visibly impressed by the house.** Not the art, not the view, not the cars. You may be delighted privately for the rest of your life. In the house, it is a room, and you work in it.

CHAPTER IV

Days one to fourteen

Learn. Do not improve.

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Resist the single strongest and most destructive instinct of a competent new person.

4.1 · The instinct that ends first roles

You are capable, you have just finished eight weeks of study, you have a toolkit, and you can see, within four days, six things in this house that are done badly.

You will fix none of them. Not one, not for a fortnight, and I would rather you did nothing at all for a month than fix the wrong thing in week one.

4.2 · Why

What you see

What is actually there

An inefficient process

A process that exists because of something that happened in 2019 that nobody will explain to you, and that everybody remembers.

A supplier who is plainly too expensive

A supplier who came to the house at two in the morning when a pipe burst on Christmas Eve, and who will therefore be used until he retires.

A member of staff doing a task that is not theirs

A member of staff who has done it for eleven years, and for whom it is a matter of standing, and who will destroy you if you take it away.

A system that could be automated

A system the principal likes, exactly as it is, for a reason that is about them rather than about efficiency.

THE RULE OF THE FIRST FORTNIGHT

Everything in a house that looks stupid has a history. Find the history before you touch the thing.

And the fastest way to find it is to ask the person who has been there longest, privately, without any suggestion that you intend to change it. You will be told, and you will be glad you asked, and they will have decided that you are all right.

4.3 · What you do instead

You run the Week 4 observation log, every night, for fourteen nights. The six categories. Facts only. And you build the beginnings of the preference file, and you learn the house, and you do the job exactly as it is currently done, **including the parts you can see are wrong**.

At the end of the fortnight you will have a list. Keep it. Do not act on it. It is the most valuable document you will produce in your first year and its time has not come.

CHAPTER V

Days fifteen to forty-five

The first standard, and the first correction

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Introduce your first change correctly.

Survive the first mistake, which will happen in this window.

5.1 · The first change

One. Small. Invisible. Chosen because it removes friction from the principal's life, and never because it makes your own work tidier.

You do not announce it. You do not propose it in a meeting. You do not present a plan for improving the household. **You simply do it, quietly, and it works, and nothing is said.**

And then you do the second one three weeks later. This is how a house changes: by accretion, invisibly, without anybody ever having had to agree to a programme of reform led by a person they have known for a month.

5.2 · The first mistake

It will happen in this window. Almost always between day twenty and day forty, when the initial vigilance drops and the systems are not yet yours.

AND YOU ALREADY KNOW WHAT TO DO

Fact. Fix. Ownership. Three sentences, under thirty seconds, the same day, in a flat voice.

"The table at eight is gone. I have Le Jardin at eight fifteen, same room, car adjusted. I should have confirmed in writing on Monday and I did not."

It is Week 4, and it is Week 5, and you wrote those three sentences out in advance precisely so that you would not have to compose them on the worst morning of your first month. Read your escalation card. It is why it exists.

The first mistake, handled correctly, is worth more than a flawless month. Because it answers the only question that actually matters about you, and it answers it early, and it answers it permanently: bad news travels through this person at full speed.

CHAPTER VI

Days forty-six to ninety

The systems, and the review nobody will offer you

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Build the household manual.

Ask for the review that will not be offered.

6.1 · The manual

Now you write it. The household manual from Week 5: the house, the people, the standards, the rhythms, the emergencies. Nobody will ask you to do this. Nobody will notice you doing it. And it is the single act that most reliably converts a new employee into a senior one.

Because a house that has been written down is a house that can be run, and a person who has written it down is a person who has understood the whole of it. **And you will be replaceable, which is exactly why you will be promoted.**

6.2 · The review

At around ninety days, you ask for a review. Nobody will offer you one, because private households do not do reviews, and this is precisely why you should ask.

THE THREE QUESTIONS, AND NO OTHERS

"What is working?"

"What would you like done differently?"

"Is there anything I have not noticed?"

And then you say nothing at all, and you write down every word, and you do not defend a single thing, not one, however unfair, however factually wrong, however much you want to. You say thank you, and you change it, and you never mention it again.

That last question, "is there anything I have not noticed", is the one that will produce the real answer, and it is the one that almost nobody has the courage to ask. It is also, quietly, the most senior sentence in this document.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Days 1 to 14: learn, and improve nothing. Everything that looks stupid has a history.

Days 15 to 45: one small invisible change, and the first mistake, handled in three sentences.

Days 46 to 90: write the manual nobody asked for, then ask for the review nobody will offer.

CHAPTER VII

The staff

How a new person is really received

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand what the house is doing when you arrive.

Earn the housekeeper, who is the whole game.

7.1 · What is actually happening

You arrive full of goodwill, and you meet people who are polite, helpful, and completely closed.

Understand what they are seeing. They have watched people arrive before. Some of those people were arrogant. Some tried to reorganise everything and left in four months, having made everyone's life harder. Some were perfectly nice and were gone by Christmas.

They are not being cold. They are waiting to see whether you are worth investing in, and they are entirely right to wait, and it will take about six weeks.

7.2 · How you earn them

- You take the unglamorous task, once, visibly, without being asked and without mentioning it. This is worth more than four months of pleasantness, and it is noticed by everybody, immediately.
- You never make their day harder. A briefing at ten at night. A change of plan at five. A request that could have waited until morning. Every one of those is a withdrawal, and they are all being counted.
- You defend them upward, once, when it costs you something. Week 5: credit goes down, responsibility comes up. The staff will observe you do this, and the day you do it, the house changes.
- You do not become their friend, and you do not become their confidante. You are warm, boundaried, and fair. The new person who joins the complaining in week three has chosen a side, and it is the losing one.

- **You are the same on Tuesday as on Sunday.** Consistency is the rarest quality in a household, and it is the one they are actually measuring.

7.3 · The housekeeper

If there is a long-serving housekeeper, she is the most important relationship in your first ninety days. She has no title, no budget, and no authority over you. She has nineteen years, the principal's trust, and a view of you that will be asked for and given in a single sentence.

Treat her as senior to you, because she is. Ask her opinion, genuinely, and take it. You will never regret this, and there is no faster route into a house.

CHAPTER VIII

The tests of the first ninety days

None of them will look like tests

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the five tests of the entry period.

The test	What it looks like, and what it is measuring
The confidence	A small piece of information given to you for no reason, by someone, early. Two weeks later they will learn whether it travelled. It always travels, and it always comes back.
The discrepancy	A small expense that is slightly wrong, in your favour. Too small to be worth mentioning. Mention it, immediately, in writing.
The invitation to complain	A member of staff criticising the house, or a principal, in front of you, and then pausing. The pause is the test. Do not fill it.
The out-of-hours request	Something small, on a Sunday, that you were not obliged to do. How you respond in the first month sets the expectation for four years, so respond as you intend to continue, which means neither martyrdom nor reluctance.
The moment they are difficult	It will happen, and it will be undeserved, and it will be about something that is not you. What is being measured is whether your standard changes when their mood does. It must not. That is the entire qualification.

CHAPTER IX

The seven ways new people fail

And not one of them is competence

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise your own failure mode before it happens.

The failure	What it looks like from inside the house
The reformer	Arrived, saw everything that was wrong, and set about fixing it. Alienated the staff by week three. Gone by month five, still convinced she was right, and she was, and it did not matter at all.
The comparer	"In my last house we did it this way." Said four times. The fourth one was the last one, and nobody told her why the room went quiet.
The impressed	Visibly delighted by the art, the cars, the plane. It reads as appetite, and appetite is the one thing a household cannot have inside it.
The confidante	The best people fail here. Week 3, in a real house, and it will feel exactly like being chosen. It is not.
The invisible	So terrified of overstepping that she did nothing at all for two months. Anticipation requires evidence, and it also requires action, and there is a difference between restraint and absence, and the house can feel it.
The martyr	Never took a day off, never said no, worked every Sunday, and made sure it was known. She was exhausted by month four, resentful by month six, and gone by month nine, and she believed until the end that she had been undervalued.
The one who hid a mistake	Not the mistake. The forty minutes she spent deciding whether to mention it. Week 3, and it is the only one on this list from which there is no recovery.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

Almost nobody fails at this on competence. They fail on posture, on ego, and on silence.

Every one of the seven is predictable, and therefore every one of them is avoidable.

You know which of the seven is yours. Write it on the first page of your entry plan.

Glossary

The unspoken trial · The first ninety days. Not described as a trial, not reviewed, and entirely decisive.

The history · The reason a thing that looks stupid is done that way. There is always one, and it is usually a person.

The first change · One. Small. Invisible. After day fifteen. Never announced.

The manual · The written system of the house, produced by day ninety, that nobody asked you for.

The ninety-day review · The review you request, because nobody offers it. Three questions, and you defend nothing.

The unglamorous task · The thing nobody wants to do, taken once, without being asked and without being mentioned. The fastest route into a household.

The seven failures · Reformer, comparer, impressed, confidante, invisible, martyr, and the one who hid a mistake.

Self-assessment

The last written work of the programme. Answer it as though your first day were Monday.

1. What is the actual objective of your first ninety days? Answer without using the word impress.
2. What do you never research before your first day, and why does it feel like diligence?
3. On day four you see six things being done badly. Write what you do about each of them, and defend your answer.
4. Explain the rule of the first fortnight in one sentence, and give a real example of a thing that looks stupid and has a history.
5. Describe your first change: what makes something the right first change, and what makes something the wrong one?
6. Your first mistake happens on day thirty-one. Write the three sentences, now, before you need them.
7. Why does writing the household manual, which makes you replaceable, get you promoted?
8. Write the three questions of the ninety-day review, and describe exactly what you do while they answer.
9. How do you earn a housekeeper of nineteen years? Give three specific acts, not qualities.
10. Which of the seven failures is yours? Not the one you admire least. The one you would actually commit. Write it down, and write what you will do about it.

Further study

- **Reread your Week 3 code of conduct.** Then read it again on the night before your first day. It was written for that night, and you did not know it at the time.
- **Print your escalation card and keep it somewhere you can find it in four seconds.** You will need it between day twenty and day forty. Everybody does.
- **Write the names down on day one.** All of them. Learn them that night. There is no single act with a higher return in this entire profession.
- **Put a date in your diary, now, ninety days after any start date, that says: ask for the review.** You will not remember, and you will not want to, and it is the sentence that separates the people who are kept from the people who are not.

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